



Bangladeshi caretaker regime Fakhruddin Ahmed on the sidelines of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) summit in March this year, Mukherjee, who visited Dhaka, also raised the issue of terrorists on Bangladesh soil. But little has been done on this front. In fact, just last month when the home secretaries of the two countries met, Delhi handed over a thick dossier to Bangladesh with details of over 350 fugitives that India is seeking from Dhaka, besides a list of 172 terror camps and those training insurgent groups from the north-east. This is not something which India has pointed out for the first time. A few years ago, when it had indicated that Anup Chetia and Paresh Barua, top leaders of the United Liberation Front of Assam (ULFA) were in Bangladesh, Dhaka had denied their presence.

While the security establishment in Delhi is worried, the Foreign Office is in favour of a soft approach. It still wants to give the new caretaker regime a chance to come clean on the issue. "Bangladesh has given us some assurances, and we are hopeful that the security cooperation will go in a positive direction," says Pinak Ranjan Chakravarty, India's high commissioner to Bangladesh. Though South Block believes that the handover of suspects of Hyderabad blasts and other fugitives will be an acid test, it wants to have cordial ties with the present regime. "Compared to the Khaleda Zia government, which was openly har-

NEIGHBOURING WOES

■ The caretaker Government has clamped down on mainstream politicians and has hanged home grown fundamentalist leaders like Bangla Bhai but foreign terrorist groups like Al Qaeda still remain active.

■ In August, India gave a list of 172 terror camps still running on Bangladeshi territory. No action has been taken against them.

■ Large parts of the 4,096 km border with India still remain unfenced. With infiltration of terrorists easy and undetectable, terror groups like LeT, and HuJI use the country to launch attacks in India.

■ Religious parties like Jamaat have increased their influence with growing poverty and unemployment becoming a potent ground for recruiting jihadis.

bouring anti-India elements and terrorist groups, the present regime has been neutral, but we are yet to see any credible action in curbing terrorist groups on the ground," says a source in the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

Even though officials convey optimism, the reality on the ground points to the opposite. Like the Hamza case illustrates, the caretaker regime is turning out to be no different from the earlier one, given the fact that ISI has almost been given a free run in mounting

THE ENEMY WITHIN: Bangladesh continues to harbour ULFA outlaws anti-India operations from its soil. It is after all easy to infiltrate from the long porous Indo-Bangladeshi border. Doubts have also been raised regarding the intentions of the Bangladeshi Army led by its chief Lt General Moeen U. Ahmed, who is perceived to be close to Islamabad. He had served as a defence attache in the Bangladeshi mission in Islamabad. In the war doctrine of the Bangladesh Army, the imaginary country Foxland, against which most war gaming is done, is India. The army calls the shots in the present regime and Ahmed's role in checking anti-India elements is suspect.

What is worse is that even though more than 170 top politicians, including Zia have been arrested and cases filed against them, the caretaker regime has failed to curb the mushrooming of religious and fundamentalist organisations that are being encouraged by religious parties like the Jamaat-e-Islami. Affiliated groups of Al Qaeda, such as Zadid Al Qaeda have expanded their presence in the country. Analysts believe there is a deliberate design in not addressing India's security concerns. The feeling is that it is strategically advantageous for Dhaka to keep Delhi on the backfoot since it gives Dhaka a leverage in bargaining for economic and other sops in exchange of some action against insurgent groups operating from its soil.

Bangladesh has also continued to stonewall India's attempts to forge an extradition treaty—India had sent a draft in 2003. It has been four years since but there has been no comment from Dhaka on the issue. While India has no option but to engage with the present regime, officials believe it was time the Government shed diplomatic niceties and sent a strong signal to Dhaka that it will not accept any anti-India activity from Bangladeshi soil.

The handing over of top fugitives like Hamza and other perpetrators of the Hyderabad blasts, they suggest, should be the litmus test and a zero-tolerance approach should replace the present give-them-time attitude. Any further dithering would only encourage Dhaka to keep up its double game.